

Seawall height in Key Colony Beach

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

KEY COLONY BEACH • MONROE COUNTY

5.5

 ft above mean sea level

Key Colony Beach is the only jurisdiction in Monroe County that sets a seawall elevation, and it is the most prescriptive seawall code in the Keys - height, cap width, length, shape and even rubbing posts are all fixed. Note the datum: the city states its rule in mean sea level, not NAVD88, and the two are not interchangeable.

The detail

THE FIGURE	5.5 ft above mean sea level for the first seawall on a canal, and for all subsequent walls on that canal. Rubbing posts, pilings and similar projections are excluded from the measurement. Sec. 5-51(a).
MIND THE DATUM	That is mean sea level, not NAVD88. The ordinance predates NAVD88 in local practice and we have found no published conversion, so take the figure as written and get your datum from your survey.
IF YOU CONNECT TO NEIGHBOURS	Joining existing walls at both ends, your top matches the higher of the two. Joining at one end, it matches that one. Sec. 5-51(b) and (c).
IF NOTHING ADJOINS	Your top matches the highest existing seawall on the same side of the same canal. Sec. 5-51(d).
CAP WIDTH	Not less than 5 feet and not more than 10 feet. Sec. 5-52.
FULL FRONTAGE	The seawall must run the full length of the water frontage, with no exception for lots with more than one frontage. Sec. 5-53.
SLOPING WALLS ARE BANNED	Seawalls must be perpendicular and the cap horizontal. Sloping seawalls are not permitted. Sec. 5-54.
RETURN SLABS	Not less than five inches thick. Sec. 5-55.
RUBBING POSTS	Not less than 5 feet nor more than 10 feet above mean sea level. Sec. 5-56.

A SEAWALL MAY BE MANDATORY	The city's position is that seawalls are the most suitable erosion control for most locations here, and they are required wherever permitted by state or federal agencies. Sec. 5-25.
ORDER OF PERMITS	The city issues its permit only after you hold the required approvals from the Army Corps of Engineers, FDEP or any other required agency. Sec. 5-30.
YOU MUST MAINTAIN IT	Owners must keep a seawall in safe and sturdy condition. Sec. 5-62. Seawalls are deemed structures subject to city inspection and enforcement, with a notice procedure for an unsafe or deteriorated wall. Sec. 6-45.

Where this comes from: City of Key Colony Beach Code of Ordinances Ch. 5, Art. III, Div. 5, Seawall Location and Design Standards, Secs. 5-50 to 5-56, and Secs. 5-25, 5-30, 5-62, 6-45

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.